

Building Your Letter Around One Idea: "Goldman Is One Instrument"

A full Sam-style draft on the "conductor of the orchestra" theme — annotated, plus a 300-word cut. Aimed at a client-facing role.

The craft lesson first (why this works)

Sam's Optiver letter commits **totally** to one idea — Bayesian probability / maximum-EV — and lets it run through every paragraph as a single thread. That single-mindedness is *why* it lands. A letter that touches five themes says nothing; a letter that drives one idea all the way through feels inevitable.

You've picked your thread: **Goldman's edge is integration — the firm is one instrument, and the client-facing seat is the conductor.** Everything in the draft below serves that one idea. That's the discipline. Watch how it never wanders.

Why it's a perfect fit for a client-facing role: the "conductor" in Jack's metaphor is the salesperson — the client-facing person who orchestrates research, execution, and the rest of the firm around what the client needs. So this theme doesn't just show you understand the business model; it argues for the exact seat you want. Two birds, one idea.

Part A — The full draft (Sam-style, ~360 words)

This is the shape and the connective tissue done for you. The only things left are the [bracketed] parts — your real evidence — because those are the un-fakeable bits only you can supply. Read it once straight through, then read the annotations in Part B.

Dear Sir/Madam,

At Goldman's insight events, one image reframed how I understood the firm. Listening to Jack McFarren describe his role in UK sales, he called the salesperson "*the conductor of the orchestra*" — surrounded by research, execution and the commodities desk, his job was to pull it all together and play the music the client wanted. I had arrived thinking of an investment bank as a set of separate desks; I left understanding it as a single instrument, and the client-facing seat as the point where the whole of it converges.

That integration is not a slogan — it is how the firm is deliberately built. In the private credit session, Ahmed described Goldman consolidating once-competing internal teams into a single platform, so that a client meets one firm rather than many. One of the research analysts spoke about the "*optionality to attack a question from many angles*" — commodities desks, macro desks — that a smaller firm simply cannot offer. What struck me was that Goldman's edge is the integration itself: the product is the entire platform, conducted for one client.

That is the work I am drawn to. **[EXPERIENCE A — a specific time you were the connector: you enjoyed pulling different people, skills or resources together to deliver something for someone else].** What I found

limiting in **[EXPERIENCE B — a narrower, more siloed role]** was **[the specific thing you disliked — working in isolation / one repetitive task / never seeing the whole picture]**. A client-facing role at Goldman resolves exactly that: the conductor's seat, where the reward is not doing one thing alone, but orchestrating the best of an entire firm around what a client is trying to achieve.

The discipline Jack described stayed with me — after every client meeting, ask *what did they want from it, and how can we add value to what they do*. Another panellist sharpened it: the job is understanding what makes a client look smart to their own boss. **[YOUR "CONDUCTOR" STORY — one specific time you coordinated different people/resources/skills to solve a problem for someone else, and what it produced]**. That is the version of client service I want to build a career in.

I would value the opportunity to begin that at Goldman — the one firm whose entire model is designed to be conducted around the client. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully, **[Your Name]**

Part B — Annotated: what every paragraph is doing

Learn the moves by seeing them fire. (Moves are from the masterclass: Swap Test, Show-Don't-Tell, Concrete-First, Theme → Me Mirror, One-Level-Down.)

¶1 — **The hook**. Opens on a *specific moment* (Jack, the exact phrase), not "I have always admired Goldman." *Concrete-first*. And it immediately plants the one idea — "a single instrument... the client-facing seat as the point where the whole converges" — which the rest of the letter will pay off. Note the mini-arc even here: *I arrived thinking X, I left understanding Y*. That's a story in one sentence.

¶2 — **Mirror the DNA, one level down**. This is where most people write "I love the collaborative culture" and die. Instead: two *specific* proofs the integration is real and deliberate — Ahmed's consolidation, the analyst's "optionality." Then the thesis line: *"Goldman's edge is the integration itself: the product is the entire platform."* That's an observation about **how the firm makes money** — a completely different altitude from flattery. *One-level-down* + *swap-proof* (you can't write this about another bank you didn't study).

¶3 — **The like/dislike engine (the heart — your evidence)**. Pure Sam mechanic: *liked being the connector (Experience A) → found the siloed role limiting (Experience B) → the conductor's seat is the resolution*. This makes the client-facing role the **logical destination** of your story, not a wish. This paragraph is where *you* must supply real evidence — it's the un-fakeable core.

¶4 — **Proof of understanding + client-facing craft**. Shows you didn't just hear a nice metaphor — you absorbed the *discipline* underneath it (Jack's "what did they want from the meeting," the "make the client look smart to their boss" reframe). Then *your* conductor story proves you already operate this way. *Theme → Me Mirror* + *Show-Don't-Tell*.

¶5 — **Close**. One genuine line that lands the whole thread: Goldman is *the one firm whose model is designed to be conducted for the client*. No prestige, no adjectives, no money. Your voice.

What makes the whole thing "different": one idea, driven all the way through; every claim shown not told; every firm reference specific to *your* event; and it argues for the exact seat you want. Run it through the Swap Test — almost nothing survives being about another bank. That's the goal.

Part C — The 300-word cut (for Goldman's actual motivation box)

Remember: Goldman EMEA uses a ~300-word **motivation statement in the portal**, not an uploaded letter (no "Dear Sir/Madam", no sign-off). Here's the same idea compressed to fit. (~295 words with your parts in.)

At Goldman's insight events, one image reframed how I saw the firm. Jack McFarren called the salesperson "*the conductor of the orchestra*" — surrounded by research, execution and commodities, pulling it together to play the music the client wants. I had thought of a bank as separate desks; I left seeing it as a single instrument, with the client-facing seat as the point where the whole firm converges.

That integration is deliberate, not a slogan: Ahmed described consolidating once-competing teams into one platform so a client meets one firm; a research analyst described the "*optionality to attack a question from many angles*" a smaller firm can't offer. Goldman's edge is the integration — the product is the whole platform, conducted for one client.

That is the work I want. **[EXPERIENCE A — where you were the connector who pulled people/resources together for someone]**, and what I found limiting in **[EXPERIENCE B]** was **[what you disliked]**. A client-facing role here is the resolution: the conductor's seat, orchestrating an entire firm around what a client is trying to achieve.

Jack's discipline stayed with me — after every meeting, ask what the client wanted and how you add value to *their* goals; another panellist put it as understanding what makes a client look smart to their own boss. **[YOUR CONDUCTOR STORY — one specific time you coordinated different people/skills to solve someone's problem]**. That is the client service I want to build a career in — which is why I'm applying to Goldman, the one firm whose model is designed to be conducted around the client.

Part D — What to fill in (and how to find it)

Three blanks. Get these honest and specific and the letter is genuinely yours:

1. **[EXPERIENCE A — you as the connector]**. A time you *enjoyed* being the one who pulled different people/skills/resources together for someone. Doesn't have to be finance — a group project you coordinated, a team you captained, a job where you linked people to what they needed, a society role. What did you *orchestrate*?
2. **[EXPERIENCE B — the siloed one you found limiting]**. A role/task that was narrow, isolated, repetitive, or gave you no view of the whole. The *contrast* is what powers the story (Sam's "liked X, lacked Y").
3. **[YOUR CONDUCTOR STORY]**. The most important: one specific 15-second story where you coordinated several people/resources/skills to solve a problem *for someone else*, and it worked. This is what proves — without claiming — that you already think like a conductor.

Two honesty checks before you submit: - **Names:** you *heard* Jack and Ahmed on panels — "listening to Jack describe..." is honest; don't write "I spoke with" unless you did (rooftop drinks count). Verify spellings/titles (the transcript flags some as best-interpretation). - **Voice:** once your parts are in, read it aloud and rewrite anything that sounds like a robot into how *you'd* actually say it. Goldman screens for AI/generic — your natural voice is the asset.

Send me those three real answers (and your CV) and I'll help you sharpen the exact wording of your parts so the whole thing reads seamlessly in your voice.